long tenures in staff. The latter may have all the qualifications but many of them are clever and calculative opportunists or careerists, unbeatable on paper! They are ticket punchers. They are the ones who even count the months while they are in command. To such commanders, I had a standard refrain, ‘are you pregnant?’ whenever they spoke of the number of ‘months’ they had been in command of troops. Before one is selected to command a battalion or a regiment in the combat arms, one has to have a minimum of two performance appraisal reports as a company, battery or a squadron commander. This implies that an officer should have served with troops for at least one-and-a-half to two years. There are some officers who buck the system by doing just the bare minimum time in command assignments, and like a submarine, take a deep dive and resurface only when the next rank is due. During this interregnum they take up a safe staff job or study leave. Further, some of them try to manipulate their posting under someone they have already worked with and, if possible, in an area where they have served earlier. And there are some who are the smooth talkers and by flaunting terms and clichés used in foreign armies, they try to impress others. They might carry the day in a sand-model discussion, but when it comes to the ‘real’ thing on the ground, they begin to shiver under stress and give the impression that their knees are about to buckle under! Such fair weather high-fliers are potentially dangerous. Though some of them may reach high ranks in peace time, they make poor leaders and are more than likely to be disasters in war. Such cases are found in most armies and we are not an exception.

When the results of the first selection grade promotion of my batch (25th NDA Course) from major to lieutenant colonel were announced in 1980, I had put in about sixteen years of service. By then, I had earned four or five reports as a company commander, whereas there were a few of our course mates who got deferred for promotion, because they did not have even two mandatory reports! Where had they been serving all those years? It would be reasonable to assume that most of us would be reluctant to take a chance with a greenhorn cardiac surgeon, and would prefer to be operated upon by a more experienced one. Therefore, what makes us feel that our